

Annotation Transfer Tool

<https://github.com/aiyshwary/Annotation-Transfer-Tool>

Python

Computer Vision

AWS S3

CVAT

PyTorch

OVERVIEW

A smart auto-annotation pipeline that leverages deep image similarity to transfer labels from previously human-annotated images to new unannotated ones, significantly reducing manual labeling effort in computer vision workflows.

IMPACT

Reduced manual annotation effort by automatically transferring labels from existing human-labeled images to new images using deep feature similarity and a modular 8-step pipeline integrated with CVAT and AWS S3.

TECHNICAL WALKTHROUGH

High-level overview

This project is an Annotation Transfer Tool that significantly reduces manual labeling effort by automatically transferring annotations from previously human-labeled images to new images using deep image similarity.
In short:

Find similar images → **reuse their annotations** → **verify visually** → export back to CVAT

What problem does it solve?

Manual annotation is slow and expensive. Even auto-annotation models struggle when data is limited or domain-specific. This tool leverages already annotated images and transfers their labels to new images by identifying visually similar samples using deep learning.

Core idea

Instead of predicting bounding boxes from scratch, the tool searches for visually similar images using deep feature embeddings and transfers annotations from the closest matches.

This makes it:

Faster than manual labeling

More reliable than blind auto-annotation

Especially effective in low-variation industrial datasets

End-to-end pipeline explanation

Configuration-driven setup

The entire pipeline is controlled through a single `config.yml`, which defines input paths, S3 locations, and processing parameters.

This makes the pipeline:

Reproducible

Easy to reconfigure across datasets

Image & annotation ingestion

Images are downloaded from S3 based on a Datamaro JSON file exported from

CVAT. Only relevant images are pulled, avoiding unnecessary data transfer.

Scripts involved:

s3_download.py

datuamaru_crop_sort.py

Label normalization

Annotations are normalized into a consistent format so that downstream processes like cropping and similarity matching work reliably.

Script:

normalize_labels.py

Crop, mask, and label generation

For each annotated object, the tool generates image crops, corresponding label files, and binary masks.

This creates a reference library of labeled object appearances.

Script:

crops_generation.py

Deep image similarity search

A deep learning-based feature extractor generates embeddings for image crops. Using DeepImageSearch, the tool identifies visually similar images across the dataset.

Script:

CheckSimilarityScore_gpu.py

This is where:

Feature-based search replaces brute-force labeling

Previously labeled examples guide new annotations

Annotation transfer & correction

Annotations from the most similar matches are transferred to the target images. Any mismatches or incorrect labels are corrected and mapped back to the original annotation files.

Script:

Correcting_matching.py

This step ensures:

Label consistency

Reduced noise from similarity errors

Visualization for validation

Both normalized and denormalized annotations are visualized to verify correctness before final export.

Scripts:

visualization_normalized.py

visualization_denormalized.py

This acts as a human-in-the-loop sanity check.

Export back to CVAT

Finally, the updated annotations are converted back into Datumaro JSON format, making them directly uploadable to CVAT.

Script:

fetch_json_data.py

Two ways to run the system

Full automation

-

The entire pipeline can be run with a single command (`run.py`) for batch processing.

Step-by-step execution

-

Each stage can also be executed independently for debugging, validation, or partial runs.

Interactive demo

A Jupyter notebook (`DEMO.ipynb`) demonstrates the entire workflow interactively, making it easy to understand intermediate outputs and debug results.

One-liner summary

I built a deep similarity–based annotation transfer system that automatically reuses existing human annotations to label new images, reducing manual labeling effort while maintaining annotation quality.

KEY DETAILS

- Downloads labeled images from AWS S3 and extracts annotations from Datamaro JSON format.

- Generates image crops, normalizes labels, and creates masks for each labeled region.

- Uses DeepImageSearch (GPU-accelerated) to identify the most visually similar labeled images for each new image.

- Transfers and corrects annotations from matched images, then exports back to CVAT-compatible JSON.

- Includes normalized and denormalized visualization scripts and an interactive Jupyter demo notebook.